

Designing a Minecraft World That Carries Identity and Community Knowledge

Concise Mini-Unit Packet

Layered Genius: Designing for Joy and Identity

Grade 4–5 Computer Science / Digital Literacy mini-unit centered on Minecraft Education, multimodal meaning-making, identity-safe design, and community knowledge

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Course	EDU498: Literacy Learning as Social Practice
Class Session	Class 7: Towards a Pursuit of Identity
Assignment	Layered Genius: Designing for Joy and Identity
Mini-Unit Focus	Minecraft world-building as identity, community, and coding literacy
Student Profile	Ethan, Student 5, Computer Science
Submission Date	June 10, 2026

This draft uses Piter's Puzzle Plan and EQUITAS lens to treat Minecraft Education as a literacy space where students can build, code, debug, explain, and represent meaning without being reduced to one narrow academic mode.

*Author's Context Note: This version keeps the Class 7 focus on **Joy** and **Identity**, while concisely adding the pieces visible in stronger mini-unit examples: a fuller lesson sequence, all five pursuits, assessment evidence, a sample model, and student-facing appendix tools.*

Mini-Unit Snapshot

Class 7 task: build from the Joy + Identity checkpoint into a concise mini-unit packet that also names Skills, Intellect, and Criticality clearly enough for feedback and future expansion.

Grade / discipline: Grade 4–5 Computer Science / Digital Literacy

Student profile: Ethan, a Seneca / Haudenosaunee and mixed-identity student who enjoys coding, game design, robotics, collaboration, outdoor learning, and community storytelling.

Mini-unit focus: Students use Minecraft Education to plan and begin building a small digital place that communicates identity, community knowledge, belonging, or future possibility.

Essential question: How can code, design, and digital place-making communicate who we are, what matters to us, and what our communities know?

Unit context and purpose: This three-lesson unit is designed for a Grade 4–5 Computer Science / Digital Literacy setting using Minecraft Education. Students use digital world-building as a literacy practice: they plan, code, debug, label, explain, and share a digital place that carries meaning. The purpose is to help students see coding not only as technical correctness, but as authorship, identity, community knowledge, and audience-aware design.

Three-lesson arc:

- **Lesson 1: Plan a Meaningful Place.** Choose a place concept, sketch it, name meaningful features, and begin one prototype.
- **Lesson 2: Build and Debug.** Use Minecraft / MakeCode to build, test, revise, and add at least one coded or repeated design feature.
- **Lesson 3: Share and Reflect.** Present the world, explain design choices, and respond to peer feedback.

Source Trail and Rationale for the Pick

This draft grows from the Class 7 prompt, the Class 7 tracker, the earlier base-selection memo, the Class 3 joy commitment, and the Grade 4 Minecraft placement evidence. The closest base was the existing Minecraft Education coding lesson family because it already included real evidence of debugging, peer teaching, block-counting, and multimodal digital literacy.

The other options were useful but less direct for this first draft. Squishy circuits would fit Sofia and embodied science literacy well, but the unit arc was less developed. AI/coding-as-literacy would be powerful for EQUITAS and criticality, but it was too complex for a first Joy + Identity lesson.

The model mini-units in the comparison folder showed that stronger final packets usually include unit context, multiple lesson plans, assessment evidence, sample materials, appendices, and reflection. This revision adds those pieces in a concise way without turning the document into a long final packet.

Student Profile and Identity Safety

Ethan's profile matters because the lesson can recognize him as a coder, designer, storyteller, and community-minded problem solver. The lesson should not ask him to perform culture for the class. Instead, it offers identity-safe choice: students may build from lived experience, imagination, community, interests, family, land, language, hobbies, or future hopes.

Because Ethan's profile includes Seneca / Haudenosaunee heritage, culturally specific symbols or stories should be student-chosen and handled with care. Private disclosure is never required. Fictionalized, symbolic, or aspirational places are valid.

Pursuits Alignment

Pursuit	How this draft addresses it
Joy	Students experience choice, visible progress, peer support, debugging as discovery, and the satisfaction of building something shareable.
Identity	Students design a meaningful place and explain how specific features communicate belonging, community, memory, culture, or future possibility.
Skills	Students practice sequencing, decomposition, loops or repeated patterns, debugging, spatial reasoning, screenshot use, partner communication, and oral/written explanation.
Intellect	Students analyze how code, space, signs, paths, color, interaction, and audience work together to create meaning in a digital world.
Criticality	Students ask whose stories appear in digital worlds, whose are missing, how accessibility shapes belonging, and what respectful use means when cultural symbols or community knowledge are involved.

Multimodal and Multiliteracies Design

Minecraft functions here as a text students author. They read digital space, sketch a plan, build visually, use procedural thinking, explain orally, label in writing, and revise through peer feedback.

Modes included: spatial design, visual design, coding/sequencing, oral explanation, written labels or reflection, screenshots, collaboration, and peer feedback.

Access moves: sketch-first or build-first choice; projected model; partner roles; sentence stems; optional oral explanation; screenshots as memory support; chunked directions; low-floor/high-ceiling challenge options.

Lesson 1 Plan

Lesson title: Planning and Prototyping a Meaningful Minecraft Place

Duration: 60 minutes

Student-friendly target: I can plan and begin building a Minecraft place that shows something important about identity or community, and I can explain how my design choices carry meaning.

Objectives:

1. Students will choose a meaningful place connected to identity, community, belonging, or future possibility.
2. Students will break the place into smaller build/code steps.
3. Students will begin one prototype and test or revise at least one feature.
4. Students will explain one design choice using meaning, audience, and purpose.

Materials: Minecraft Education, teacher model world, projector, planning sheet, pencils or markers, optional MakeCode reference cards, and exit slip. If devices fail, students complete a paper-world storyboard and mark which steps would later be coded.

Standards connection: CSTA 1B-AP-10, 1B-AP-11, 1B-AP-15, and 1B-AP-17; ISTE Innovative Designer, Computational Thinker, Creative Communicator, and Global Collaborator.

Mins	Activity	Purpose
0–7	Show a generic Minecraft structure and a meaningful place. Ask: “What makes a place meaningful, not just well built?”	Frames design as meaning-making.
7–15	Model a small place plan: entrance, sign, path, gathering spot, and one repeated pattern that could be built or coded.	Makes decomposition and design choices visible.
15–25	Students choose a real, imagined, symbolic, or future place and sketch 3–5 important features.	Builds identity-safe agency.
25–38	Students label 3–5 build/code steps and begin a prototype in Minecraft or on paper.	Moves from idea to manageable action.
38–50	Students test one feature, debug one issue, or revise one design choice.	Treats mistakes as part of learning.
50–57	Partner share: “This place matters because...” and “One choice I made was...”	Centers oral literacy and audience.
57–60	Exit slip: “What does your place show? What is your next build/code step?”	Captures evidence and next steps.

Differentiation: Students may work alone or with roles such as builder, navigator, debugger, or explainer. Beginners may build one strong scene; advanced students may add loops, agent movement, signage, or an audience-centered accessibility feature.

Lesson 2 Plan

Lesson title: Building, Coding, and Debugging the Meaningful Place

Duration: 60 minutes

Student-friendly target: I can build and revise my Minecraft place so that at least one coded or repeated feature helps communicate meaning.

Objectives:

1. Students will build at least two meaningful features from their plan.

2. Students will use a sequence, loop, repeated structure, or agent-supported action to create or improve part of the world.
3. Students will debug one issue by naming the problem, testing a change, and recording what changed.

Mins	Activity	Purpose
0–8	Revisit planning sheets and choose one “must-build” feature and one “try-to-code” feature.	Focuses students before building.
8–15	Teacher models a short debug cycle: predict, run/test, notice, revise.	Makes debugging visible and normal.
15–42	Students build and code with partner roles. Teacher conferences using the debug log.	Develops skills and persistence.
42–52	Screenshot checkpoint: students capture or sketch one feature and label what it means.	Connects product to identity and audience.
52–60	Quick share: one success, one bug, one next step.	Builds community expertise.

Assessment evidence: debug log, teacher conference note, screenshot/sketch checkpoint, and oral explanation.

Lesson 3 Plan

Lesson title: Sharing Worlds, Reading Design, and Reflecting on Representation

Duration: 60 minutes

Student-friendly target: I can present my Minecraft place, explain how it carries identity or community knowledge, and respond respectfully to other students’ designs.

Objectives:

1. Students will explain at least two design choices and how they carry meaning.
2. Students will give peer feedback using notice/wonder language.
3. Students will reflect on whose stories are visible in digital spaces and how designers can make worlds more welcoming.

Mins	Activity	Purpose
0–8	Students prepare a two-sentence explanation and choose one screenshot or live view to show.	Supports concise presentation.
8–35	Gallery walk or paired screen-share: students explain their worlds and collect one notice/wonder comment.	Centers oral, visual, and digital literacy.
35–48	Whole-group critical question: “Whose stories do digital worlds usually show, and whose could be missing?”	Makes criticality explicit.
48–56	Students revise one sentence, sign, pathway, or accessibility feature based on feedback.	Turns feedback into action.
56–60	Exit reflection: “My world shows...” “A designer can make digital spaces more welcoming by...”	Captures final evidence.

Assessment evidence: final screenshot/live demonstration, peer feedback note, short presentation, and exit reflection.

Assessment and Evidence

Evidence collected across the unit: planning sheet, debug log, screenshots or sketches, teacher conference notes, peer feedback, short presentation, and exit reflection.

Criterion	Meeting	Developing
Meaningful design	World includes features connected to identity, community, belonging, or future possibility.	World has features, but the meaning needs clearer explanation.
Computational thinking	Student decomposes, sequences, tests, debugs, or uses a repeated/coded feature.	Student builds but needs support naming steps or debugging.
Multimodal literacy	Student uses building, visuals, code/planning, oral explanation, and written labels/reflection.	Student uses some modes but relies on one form of expression.
Critical awareness	Student can name whose stories are represented and how a design can welcome an audience.	Student notices audience or representation with prompting.

Sample and Appendix Tools

Teacher model sample: a small community garden world with an entrance path, welcome sign, gathering circle, repeated fence pattern, and one coded/agent-assisted repeated feature. The model should be meaningful but not perfect so students see revision as normal.

Planning card:

- My place is:

- This place matters because:
- Three important features are:
- My first 3–5 build/code steps are:

Debug log:

- I expected:
- What happened:
- I changed:
- I learned:

Share card:

- My world shows:
- One design choice I made was:
- One way this world welcomes people is:
- One question I still have is:

Reflection

This version responds to the comparison examples by adding the missing final-packet pieces while staying concise. Joy is built into choice, creation, debugging, peer support, and visible success. Identity is built into meaningful place-making and student control over what is shared. The lesson also protects privacy, which matters because identity-centered teaching should not require students to disclose trauma, culture, family history, or community knowledge on demand.

Muhammad’s identity pursuit helps frame the work as self-definition, not decoration. Moje, Luke, Davies, and Street help ask what identity the task makes possible. Skerrett supports the idea that students can be repositioned as capable contributors. Moje’s disciplinary literacy frame helps name coding, debugging, design, and explanation as literacy practices.

References and Working Sources

- EDU498 Class 7 prompt, *Towards a Pursuit of Identity*: “Layered Genius: Designing for Joy and Identity.”
- Muhammad, G. (2020). *Cultivating Genius*, Chapter 3: Identity.
- Moje, E. B., Luke, A., Davies, B., & Street, B. (2009). “Literacy and identity.”
- Skerrett, A. (2012). “We hatched in this class.”
- Moje, E. B. (2015). “Doing and teaching disciplinary literacy with adolescent learners.”
- Class 3 joy commitment: “belonging before building.”
- EDU498 Grade 4 Minecraft placement evidence: debugging, collaborative counting, peer teaching, and student-led problem framing.
- CSTA K–12 Computer Science Standards; ISTE Standards for Students; Minecraft Education / Make-Code support materials.